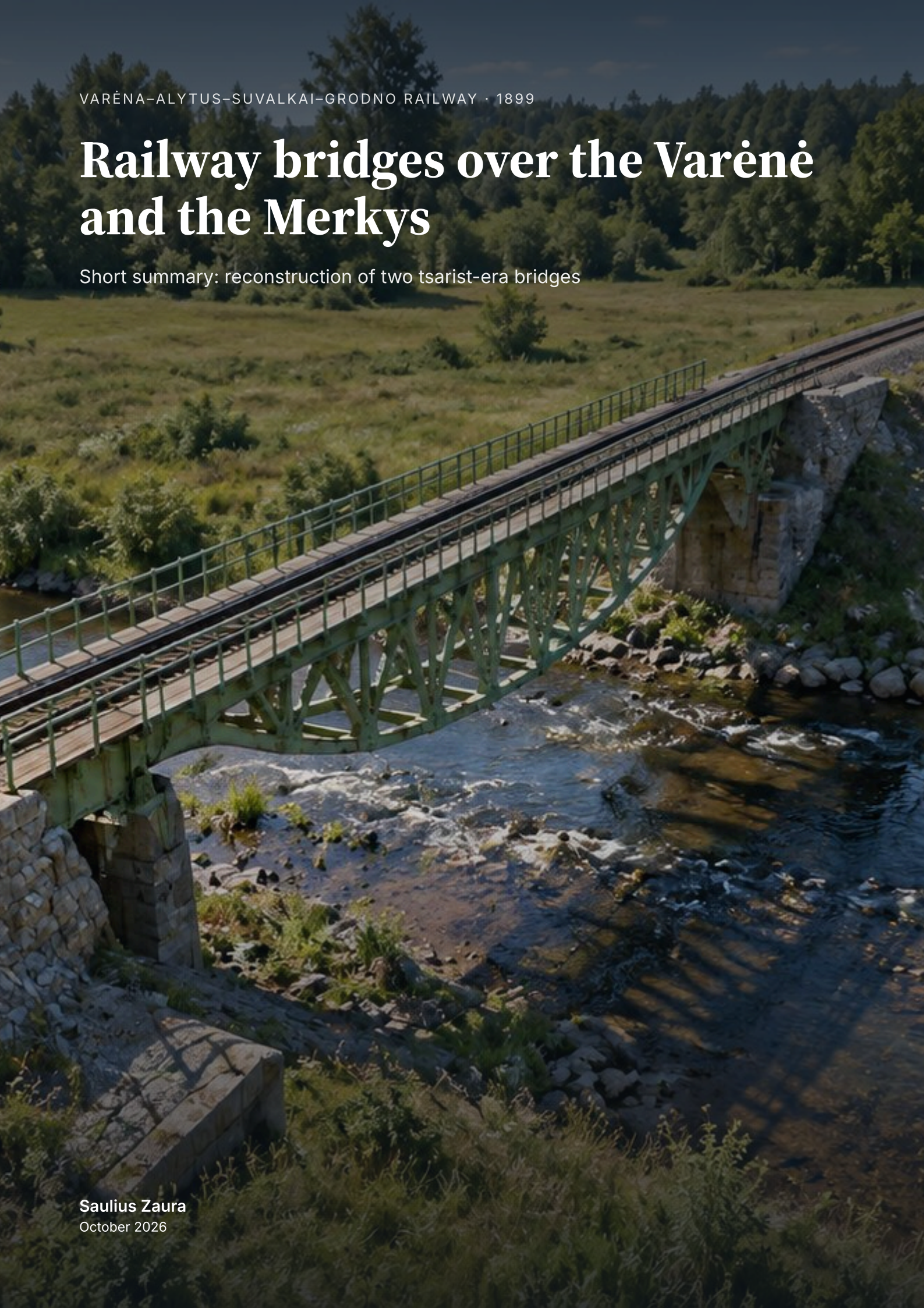
VARĖNA–ALYTUS–SUVALKAI–GRODNO RAILWAY · 1899

Railway bridges over the Varėnė and the Merkys

Short summary: reconstruction of two tsarist-era bridges



Saulius Zaura
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About the bridges

The Varėna–Alytus–Suvalkai–Grodno railway, opened in 1899 to strengthen the western border of the Russian Empire, had two steel bridges: over the Varėnė river near Glūkas village and over the Merkys near Senoji Varėna. Both were blown up in 1915; today only the stone abutments survive (Register of Cultural Property, codes 41994 and 41995).

The 1899 state of both bridges was reconstructed: the abutments were captured by photogrammetry (photogrammetric 3D record of the present state) and the steel superstructure was modelled from the Olita–Orany collection drawings. Images marked “refined with auxiliary AI image-processing tools” are renders of the 3D models whose materials and lighting were refined; the forms were not changed.



Merkys bridge (refined with auxiliary AI image-processing tools)

Bridge over the Varėnė (Glūkas bridge)

A riveted lattice truss (span ~21 m, height ~2.7 m, 1,524 mm gauge) on two stone abutments. In 1915 the Germans repaired the truss and rebuilt the bridge with a new timber intermediate support. Traffic on the section stopped in 1926 and the structure was dismantled after 1937. In 2025 a timber footbridge was renewed at the site.



The bridge in the interwar period (historic photo, colourised with auxiliary AI tools)



Reconstruction (AI-refined)



Under the bridge (AI-refined)



Truss detail (AI-refined)

Old Varėna bridge over the Merkys

A ~55 m structure with a 42.67 m (20 sazhen) fish-belly truss, two short approach spans and double masonry piers. Blown up in 1915 and rebuilt on timber supports, it was destroyed again on 7 October 1920 and never rebuilt; its trusses were reused in 1936 for a narrow-gauge bridge at Anykščiai.



Abutments after the demolition (historic photo, colourised with auxiliary AI tools)



Reconstruction (AI-refined)



Under the bridge (AI-refined)



Bridge deck (AI-refined)

3D models and key dates

Varėnė: reconstruction
skfb.ly/pOYvA

Varėnė: present state
skfb.ly/pDTF6

Merkys: reconstruction
skfb.ly/pGAB9

Merkys: present state
skfb.ly/pDGZv

How to find them. The Varėnė bridge abutments are in Glūkas village near the former Artillery Station (Grybautojų g. 8); a timber footbridge now stands on the site. The Merkys bridge abutments are near Senoji Varėna village, where the old railway embankment crosses the Merkys. On map apps search “Glūko geležinkelio tilto fragmentas” and “Senosios Varėnos geležinkelio tilto fragmentas”.

1894–1899	Railway section built; opened in 1899
1915	Russian army blows up the bridges; the Germans rebuild them (25 November: line to Varėna working again)
1920	7 October: the Merkys bridge is destroyed for good
1926	16 January: traffic Artillery Station–Alytus ends
2018	Remains entered in the Register of Cultural Property

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